

« We still believe in the *guru-shishya* combination, but the philosophy has to change »

HARENDRA SINGH

Santadeep Dey

santadeep.dey@thehindu.co.in

Harendra Singh's official designation may read 'Head Coach, India women's hockey team', but even the most astute observers could easily mistake his demeanour for that of a senior professor at a prestigious institute.

He carries himself with an air of solemn erudition, each of his measured movements steeped in an unspoken authority. His gaze, penetrating and unwavering from behind gold-rimmed spectacles perched on the bridge of his nose, scans the room as if in quiet expectation of an intellectual discourse.

When his eyes finally meet this reporter's at the far end of a hotel lobby, a flicker of warmth softens his steely features as he breaks into a wide smile.

It isn't long before the 55-year-old explains, in great detail, the current state of affairs as his team prepares to face the Netherlands, England, Spain, and Germany in the Bhubaneswar leg of the FIH Pro League 2024-25 at the Kalinga Hockey Stadium from February 15.

It has been 10 months since you took over the role of India women's coach again. How has the experience been thus far?

It's been fascinating. I took over the role on April 6 last year, with my first assignment being the Pro League (2023-24) in May. Unfortunately, it did not go as we would have liked (India finished eighth among nine teams). The biggest challenge for me was bringing the team up to international fitness standards. There were a lot of injuries in the camp, and I knew we wouldn't be able to perform at the level we wanted to.

When I took over, I had

one-on-one and team meetings because the players were mentally broken after failing to qualify for the Olympics. My priority was to get them motivated for the future. In modern hockey, fitness translates to a lot of high-speed running—not just in terms of distance covered per second but also the strength exerted. The hard work paid off in the Asian Champions Trophy, where we remained unbeaten. We ended 2024 on a high, but this is just the beginning. The 2028 Olympics is the ultimate goal.

You have always stressed the importance of fitness. What should an up-and-coming hockey



The competition for the goalkeeper position is tight because, in other departments, a midfielder can double up as a defender or a defender can play as a striker. But we have only one goalkeeper, and only the best gets that role. For now, Savita is one of the best.